

CHRIST'S COMMUNITY OF GRACE
STATEMENT OF FAITH

I. SCRIPTURE

We believe that the Holy Scriptures, consisting of the sixty-six books of the Old and New Testaments, are the written Word of God.

These 66 Books of the Bible are as follows:

Old Testament (39 Books)

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| 1. Genesis | 21. Ecclesiastes |
| 2. Exodus | 22. Song of Solomon |
| 3. Leviticus | 23. Isaiah |
| 4. Numbers | 24. Jeremiah |
| 5. Deuteronomy | 25. Lamentations |
| 6. Joshua | 26. Ezekiel |
| 7. Judges | 27. Daniel |
| 8. Ruth | 28. Hosea |
| 9. 1 Samuel | 29. Joel |
| 10. 2 Samuel | 30. Amos |
| 11. 1 Kings | 31. Obadiah |
| 12. 2 Kings | 32. Jonah |
| 13. 1 Chronicles | 33. Micah |
| 14. 2 Chronicles | 34. Nahum |
| 15. Ezra | 35. Habakkuk |
| 16. Nehemiah | 36. Zephaniah |
| 17. Esther | 37. Haggai |
| 18. Job | 38. Zechariah |
| 19. Psalms | 39. Malachi |
| 20. Proverbs | |

New Testament (27 Books)

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| 1. Matthew | 15. 1 Timothy |
| 2. Mark | 16. 2 Timothy |
| 3. Luke | 17. Titus |
| 4. John | 18. Philemon |
| 5. Acts | 19. Hebrews |
| 6. Romans | 20. James |
| 7. 1 Corinthians | 21. 1 Peter |
| 8. 2 Corinthians | 22. 2 Peter |
| 9. Galatians | 23. 1 John |
| 10. Ephesians | 24. 2 John |
| 11. Philippians | 25. 3 John |
| 12. Colossians | 26. Jude |
| 13. 1 Thessalonians | 27. Revelation |
| 14. 2 Thessalonians | |

They were given by God through human authors who were guided by the Holy Spirit. Because of this, every word of Scripture comes from God and can be fully trusted (2 Timothy 3:16–17; 2 Peter 1:20–21; 1 Corinthians 2:12–13).

We believe that the Bible is completely true and without error in its original writings. It never fails and does not contain any mistake in all that it teaches. Because it is God's Word, it is the final and highest authority in all matters of faith, teaching, and life (Psalm 19:7–9; Psalm 119:160; Proverbs 30:5; John 17:17; Matthew 5:18).

We believe that God has revealed in the Bible everything we need to know for His glory, for our salvation, and for how we should live. His Word is complete and sufficient. The Scriptures are enough to lead us to faith in Jesus Christ and to guide us in obedience (2 Timothy 3:15–17; Galatians 1:8–9; Jude 3).

We believe that the authority of Scripture does not come from the church, tradition, or human opinion, but from God Himself, who is truth. Therefore, the Bible must be believed and obeyed above all other authorities. All teachings, beliefs, and practices must be tested by Scripture, and it alone is the final judge in all matters of truth (Isaiah 8:20; 1 Thessalonians 2:13; Acts 17:11).

We believe that not every part of the Bible is equally easy to understand, but the message of salvation is clear. Anyone can understand it as they seek God with humility. The Holy Spirit helps believers understand and apply God's Word, and He also gives us confidence that the Bible is truly the Word of God (Psalm 119:130; 2 Peter 3:16; 1 Corinthians 2:12–14; 1 John 2:20, 27).

We believe that the Bible should be understood according to its context and the meaning intended by God. While a passage may be applied in different ways, it has one true meaning. When a passage is difficult to understand, it should be explained by other parts of Scripture that are clearer (Nehemiah 8:8; 2 Timothy 2:15; 2 Peter 1:20–21; Luke 24:27; Acts 17:11).

We believe that the Bible should be faithfully translated and taught in a way that people can understand, so that God's Word may live richly in His people (Colossians 3:16; Nehemiah 8:8; 1 Corinthians 14:9).

We reject the belief that the **Apocrypha** or any other writings are equal to Scripture or have authority over the church (Luke 24:27, 44; Romans 3:2).

The Apocrypha

The Apocrypha refers to a group of ancient religious books written between the Old and New Testaments. These books may contain historical accounts or moral teachings, but they are not part of the Bible and are not inspired by God in the same way as the sixty-six books of Scripture.

We do not accept these books as Scripture because:

- they were not part of the Hebrew Scriptures entrusted to the Jews (Romans 3:2)
- they were not affirmed by Jesus or the apostles (Luke 24:27, 44)
- they contain teachings that are not consistent with the rest of Scripture
- they do not carry the same authority as the inspired Word of God

Examples of Apocryphal Books

1. Tobit
2. Judith
3. Wisdom of Solomon
4. Sirach (Ecclesiasticus)
5. Baruch
6. 1 Maccabees
7. 2 Maccabees
8. and additions to Esther and Daniel

We reject any claim of new revelation that adds to, corrects, or replaces the completed written Word of God, whether through traditions, human authority, or personal experiences such as visions, dreams, or prophecies (Deuteronomy 4:2; Proverbs 30:5–6; Galatians 1:8–9; Jude 3; Revelation 22:18–19). We reject the idea that human opinion, church tradition, or cultural beliefs can be equal to or greater than the authority of God's Word (Mark 7:6–9; Colossians 2:8).

II. GOD

We believe that there is only one true and living God, who alone is worthy of our worship, trust, and obedience. In Him alone are found all wisdom, power, justice, goodness, and mercy (Deuteronomy 6:4; Isaiah 45:5–6; 1 Corinthians 8:4–6).

We believe that God is eternal, infinite, and unchanging. He is Spirit, invisible, and not limited by a physical body. He is the Creator of all things, both visible and invisible, and He rules over all things according to His will. He also upholds and sustains all things by His power (John 4:24; Psalm 90:2; Malachi 3:6; Genesis 1:1; Psalm 115:3; Isaiah 46:10; Hebrews 1:3; Colossians 1:17).

We believe that God is perfect in all His attributes. He knows everything, has all power, and is present everywhere. He is holy, righteous, just, loving, merciful, and faithful in all that He does. He hates sin and will judge all unrighteousness with perfect justice (Psalm 139:7–10; Genesis 18:14; 1 John 3:20; Isaiah 6:3; Exodus 34:6–7; Psalm 145:17; Psalm 5:5–6; Nahum 1:2–3).

We believe that God is completely independent and does not need anything from His creation. All things come from Him, exist through Him, and are for His glory. He alone is worthy of all worship and praise (Acts 17:24–25; Romans 11:36; Revelation 4:11).

We believe that this one God exists eternally in three distinct Persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Each Person is fully God, equal in power and glory, yet there is only one God (Matthew 28:19; 2 Corinthians 13:14; John 1:1; Acts 5:3–4).

We believe that the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are not the same Person, but are distinct from one another. The Father is not the Son, the Son is not the Spirit, and the Spirit is not the Father. Yet they are perfectly united in one divine nature and will, and are not divided, but one God (John 10:30; John 14:16–17).

We believe that the Father sent the Son, and the Son came to accomplish our salvation, and the Holy Spirit applies that work to believers. Though they have different roles, they are equal in their divine nature and worth (John 14:26; John 15:26; Galatians 4:4–6).

We believe that the doctrine of the Trinity is essential to the Christian faith and is clearly taught in Scripture, even though the word “Trinity” is not found in the Bible (Matthew 3:16–17; Matthew 28:19; 2 Corinthians 13:14). This truth is the foundation of our relationship with God and our worship of Him.

We believe that God alone is to be worshiped in spirit and in truth. We must not worship any created thing, including images, angels, saints, or any other being. Salvation belongs to God alone (Exodus 20:3–6; Isaiah 46:9; John 4:24; Revelation 22:8–9; 1 Timothy 2:5).

We reject the belief that there is more than one God, or that God is not truly one (Deuteronomy 6:4). We reject any teaching that denies the Trinity, including the belief that God is only one Person who appears in different forms, or that the Father, Son, and Spirit are separate gods (Matthew 28:19; 2 Corinthians 13:14). We reject any teaching that denies that Jesus Christ or the Holy Spirit is fully God (John 1:1; Colossians 2:9; Acts 5:3–4). We reject all forms of idolatry, including the worship of images, saints, angels, or any created thing (Exodus 20:3–6; Romans 1:22–23).

A. God the Father

We believe that God the Father is the first Person of the Trinity, equal with the Son and the Holy Spirit, and fully God. He works all things according to His own purpose, grace, and will (1 Corinthians 8:6; Ephesians 1:11).

We believe that He is the Creator of all things, both visible and invisible, and that everything exists by His power and for His glory (Genesis 1:1; 1 Corinthians 8:6; Revelation 4:11).

We believe that God the Father is sovereign over all things. He rules over creation and directs all events according to His perfect plan. He continually upholds and governs all things (Psalm 103:19; 1 Chronicles 29:11; Ephesians 1:11).

We believe that God is gracious, compassionate, and good in all His ways (Psalm 145:8–9). He is holy and just, and He hates sin and will judge all unrighteousness with perfect justice. He is not the author of sin, nor does He approve of sin, yet He holds all people accountable for their actions (Habakkuk 1:13; Psalm 5:5–6; 1 Peter 1:17).

We believe that God is the Creator of all people and, in that sense, Father over all creation. However, He is a loving Father in a special and saving way only to those who believe in Jesus Christ. Those who come to Him through faith in Jesus Christ are received as His children and are adopted into His family (John 1:12; Romans 8:14–15; 2 Corinthians 6:18).

We believe that, in His love and according to His purpose, God the Father sent His Son, Jesus Christ, into the world to accomplish our salvation. He forgives the sins of those who come to Him through faith in His Son and makes them His own children (John 3:16–17; Galatians 4:4–5; Ephesians 1:4–5).

We believe that God the Father hears and answers the prayers of His people and cares for them as a loving Father. He also lovingly disciplines His children for their good, that they may grow in holiness (Matthew 6:6; Romans 8:15; Hebrews 12:6–7).

We reject the idea that God is the author or approver of sin (James 1:13; 1 John 1:5; Habakkuk 1:13). We reject the belief that God is not sovereign over all things or that anything happens outside His control (Psalm 103:19; Ephesians 1:11). We reject the teaching that all people are children of God in the same spiritual sense, apart from faith in Jesus Christ (John 1:12; Romans 8:14).

B. God the Son

We believe that Jesus Christ is the eternal Son of God, the second Person of the Trinity, fully God and equal with the Father. He possesses all the divine attributes and is worthy of the same worship, honor, and obedience as the Father and the Holy Spirit. He existed before all things and shares the glory of the Father (John 1:1–3; John 10:30; John 17:5; Colossians 2:9; Colossians 1:17).

We believe that all things were created through Him and for Him, and that He continues to sustain all things by His power (John 1:3; Colossians 1:16–17; Hebrews 1:3).

We believe that in the fullness of time, the Son of God became man. Without ceasing to be God, He took on a true human nature and was conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the virgin Mary. He is therefore fully God and fully man, yet one Person, without confusion or division (Luke 1:35; John 1:14; Galatians 4:4; Philippians 2:6–7).

We believe that the Lord Jesus Christ lived a sinless life, perfectly obeying the will of the Father. He taught with authority, revealed God to us, and performed mighty works, demonstrating His divine power (Hebrews 4:15; 1 Peter 2:22; Matthew 7:29; John 1:18; John 20:30–31).

We believe that He willingly gave His life on the cross, died, and was buried. On the third day, He rose again from the dead in a real, physical body and will never die again (1 Corinthians 15:3–4; Luke 24:39; Romans 6:9).

We believe that He ascended into heaven and is now exalted at the right hand of the Father, where He reigns as King and serves as our High Priest and intercessor. All

authority in heaven and on earth has been given to Him (Acts 1:9–11; Hebrews 1:3; Hebrews 7:25; Romans 8:34; Matthew 28:18).

We believe that Jesus Christ is the only mediator between God and man and the head of the church (1 Timothy 2:5; Ephesians 1:22–23).

We believe that He will return personally and visibly in glory and power to judge the living and the dead and to establish His righteous rule forever (Acts 1:11; Acts 17:31; 2 Timothy 4:1; Revelation 22:12–13).

We reject any teaching that denies that Jesus Christ is fully God or fully man (John 1:1; Colossians 2:9; 1 John 4:2–3). We reject the belief that there is any other mediator between God and man besides Jesus Christ (1 Timothy 2:5). We reject any teaching that denies His bodily resurrection or His future return (1 Corinthians 15:14; Acts 1:11).

C. God the Holy Spirit

We believe that the Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Trinity, fully God and equal with the Father and the Son. He possesses all the attributes of God and is worthy of the same worship, honor, and obedience (Matthew 28:19; Acts 5:3–4; 2 Corinthians 3:18).

We believe that the Holy Spirit is not a force or power, but a distinct divine Person who thinks, wills, speaks, and can be grieved (1 Corinthians 12:11; Acts 28:25; Ephesians 4:30).

We believe that the Holy Spirit was active in creation, in the incarnation of Christ, and in the giving of Scripture (Genesis 1:2; Luke 1:35; 2 Peter 1:20–21).

We believe that the Holy Spirit convicts the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment (John 16:8–11).

We believe that the Holy Spirit is the sovereign agent of the new birth. He gives new life to sinners and brings them into union with Christ (John 3:5–8; Titus 3:5).

We believe that the Holy Spirit dwells in all believers, unites them to Christ, and enables them to understand and apply the Word of God (Romans 8:9; 1 Corinthians 2:12–13; 1 Corinthians 12:13).

We believe that the Holy Spirit sanctifies believers, producing in them godly character and conforming them to the image of Christ. He empowers them to live in obedience and to serve God faithfully (Galatians 5:16, 22–23; Romans 8:13–14; 2 Corinthians 3:18).

We believe that the Holy Spirit gives spiritual gifts to believers for the building up of the church and equips them for service according to His will (1 Corinthians 12:4–7; Ephesians 4:11–12).

We believe that the Holy Spirit enables believers to worship God in spirit and in truth and strengthens them in their daily walk with Him (Philippians 3:3; Ephesians 2:18; Romans 8:26–27).

We believe that the Holy Spirit seals believers and is the guarantee of their inheritance, keeping them secure until the day of redemption (2 Corinthians 1:22; Ephesians 1:13–14; Ephesians 4:30).

We believe that the Holy Spirit glorifies Jesus Christ and directs believers to Him (John 16:14).

We reject the belief that the Holy Spirit is merely a force or impersonal power (Acts 5:3–4). We reject any teaching that denies the full deity of the Holy Spirit or His personal nature. We reject the teaching that a believer may lack the Holy Spirit or must receive Him as a second, separate experience after salvation (Romans 8:9; 1 Corinthians 12:13). We reject teachings that focus on the Holy Spirit in a way that draws attention away from Jesus Christ (John 16:14). We reject the misuse of spiritual gifts that leads to confusion, disorder, or contradicts the teaching of Scripture (1 Corinthians 14:33).

III. HISTORIC CREEDS

We believe that the historic ecumenical creeds of the Christian church (Apostles' Creed, the Nicene Creed, the Athanasian Creed, and the Definition of Chalcedon) are faithful and time-tested summaries of essential biblical truth, especially concerning the Trinity and the person of our Lord Jesus Christ.

We believe that these creeds help clarify and defend the teachings of Scripture against error and have served the church throughout history as clear expressions of sound doctrine.

We believe that while these creeds are not inspired and do not have the authority of Scripture, they are valuable and trustworthy guides that accurately reflect the teaching of the Bible.

We reject the dismissal of these historic creeds as unimportant, recognizing that they serve as helpful safeguards against false teaching and theological error (2 Timothy 1:13–14). We reject the idea that these creeds are equal in authority to the Holy Scriptures or that they can stand above or replace the Word of God (2 Timothy 3:16–17). We reject any interpretation or use of these creeds that contradicts the clear teaching of Scripture (Acts 17:11).

IV. MAN

We believe that man was directly and immediately created by God in His image and likeness (Genesis 1:26–27; Genesis 2:7).

We believe that man was created good and without sin, with a rational mind, a moral nature, and the responsibility to obey God (Genesis 1:31; Ecclesiastes 7:29).

We believe that being made in the image of God means that man reflects God in a unique way among all creation, possessing dignity, value, and the ability to know, worship, and represent God (Genesis 1:26–27).

We believe that although man fell into sin, he still bears the image of God, but this image has been marred and corrupted. As a result, man's mind, will, and affections are affected by sin, though his dignity as God's image-bearer remains (Genesis 9:6; James 3:9; Romans 3:10–12).

We believe that God created mankind as male and female, equal in dignity and value, yet distinct in their God-given design and roles (Genesis 1:27; Genesis 2:18–25).

We believe that man was created to glorify God, enjoy fellowship with Him, and live according to His will (Isaiah 43:7; 1 Corinthians 10:31).

We reject the teaching that man is the result of evolution or any process apart from the direct act of God (Genesis 1:1; Genesis 2:7). We reject the idea that man is naturally good or morally neutral (Romans 3:10–12). We reject the denial of the image of God in all people or any teaching that removes the inherent dignity and value of every human being (Genesis 9:6; James 3:9). We reject the denial of the biblical distinction between male and female as created by God (Genesis 1:27).

V. THE FALL OF MAN

We believe that our first parents, Adam and Eve, were created upright and without sin, but were tempted by Satan and fell into sin by disobeying God's command (Genesis 3:1–6; Ecclesiastes 7:29; 2 Corinthians 11:3).

We believe that this act of disobedience was voluntary, and that Adam and Eve willingly chose to transgress God's Word (Genesis 3:6).

We believe that through this sin, man fell from his original righteousness and fellowship with God, bringing sin and death into the world (Genesis 3:16–19; Romans 5:12).

We believe that Adam acted as the representative head of the human race, and that through his sin, all mankind fell and became subject to sin and its consequences (Romans 5:12, 18–19; 1 Corinthians 15:22).

We believe that as a result of the fall, man became spiritually dead, separated from God, and subject to physical death and judgment (Ephesians 2:1–3; Romans 6:23).

We believe that God, in His wisdom and sovereignty, permitted the fall for His own glory, while not being the author of sin (Genesis 50:20; Acts 2:23; Romans 11:32–36; Ephesians 1:11; James 1:13).

We reject the teaching that the fall of man is a myth or merely symbolic, rather than a real historical event (Genesis 3:1–6). We reject the idea that God is the author of sin or that He caused man to sin (James 1:13). We reject the belief that man was forced or coerced into sin against his will. We reject the denial that Adam represented all humanity or that his sin affected all people (Romans 5:12).

VI. SIN

We believe that sin is any failure to conform to or transgression of the law of God, whether in thought, word, or deed (1 John 3:4; Romans 3:23).

We believe that through Adam's sin, all mankind became sinners by nature and by choice, and are under the righteous judgment of God (Romans 5:12, 18–19; Ephesians 2:1–3).

We believe that all people inherit a corrupted nature and are conceived in sin, so that from birth they are inclined toward evil and opposed to God (Psalm 51:5; Genesis 8:21; Romans 8:7–8).

We believe that man is totally depraved, meaning that sin affects every part of his being (mind, will, and affections), and that he is unable, apart from God's grace, to understand spiritual truth, please God, or come to Him (Romans 3:10–18; 1 Corinthians 2:14; Romans 8:7–8).

We believe that sin results in spiritual death, separation from God, and, apart from salvation, eternal judgment (Isaiah 59:2; Romans 6:23; 2 Thessalonians 1:9).

We believe that all people are sinners not only by nature but also by their own actions, continually sinning against God in their thoughts, words, and deeds (Mark 7:21–23; James 1:14–15).

We believe that even after regeneration, sin remains in believers, though its power is broken, and believers continue to struggle against it in this life until they are fully glorified (Romans 7:18–23; Galatians 5:17).

We reject the teaching that man is born innocent or without a sinful nature (Psalm 51:5; Romans 5:12). We reject the idea that sin is merely a social condition, weakness, or external behavior rather than a deep corruption of the heart (Jeremiah 17:9; Mark 7:21–23). We reject the belief that man has the ability to achieve righteousness or salvation by his own efforts (Romans 3:20; Ephesians 2:8–9). We reject the denial of total depravity or any teaching that claims that sin affects only part of man and not his entire being (Romans 3:10–18). We reject the claim that believers can reach sinless perfection in this life (1 John 1:8; Galatians 5:17).

VII. FREEWILL

We believe that God created man with a will, enabling him to make real and responsible choices according to his nature (Genesis 1:26–27; Ecclesiastes 7:29).

We believe that before the fall, man was free and able to obey God, yet also capable of sinning. However, through Adam's sin, all mankind fell and became corrupted in nature (Genesis 2:16–17; Romans 5:12).

We believe that because of sin, man's will is not morally free but is in bondage to sin. As a result, man is unable, apart from God's grace, to choose what is spiritually good or to come to God (Romans 3:10–12; 2 Timothy 2:26; John 6:44; Romans 8:7–8).

We believe that man still makes real choices and is fully responsible for them, but he always chooses according to his sinful nature apart from the work of God (Matthew 12:33–35; John 8:34; Romans 6:16–18).

We believe that in salvation, God graciously works in the heart through regeneration, freeing the will from its bondage to sin and enabling the sinner to repent and believe in Jesus Christ (Ezekiel 36:26–27; John 6:37; Philippians 2:13).

We believe that this work of grace does not force or coerce the will, but renews it, so that the sinner comes to Christ freely and willingly (Psalm 110:3; John 6:44).

We reject the teaching that man's will is morally neutral or naturally able to choose God apart from His grace (Romans 3:10–12). We reject the idea that man can save himself or contribute to his salvation through his own free will (Ephesians 2:8–9). We reject the belief that God's sovereignty removes human responsibility or that man is not accountable for his choices (Romans 9:19–21). We reject any view that portrays God's saving work as forcing or coercing the will against its desires.

VIII. GOSPEL

We believe that the gospel is the good news of what God has done to save sinners through the person and work of Jesus Christ (Romans 1:16; 1 Corinthians 15:1–4).

We believe that God is holy, righteous, and just, and that He created man for His glory. However, all people have sinned against Him and are under His righteous judgment (Romans 3:23; Romans 6:23).

We believe that Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, became man, lived a sinless life, and perfectly fulfilled the law of God (John 1:14; Hebrews 4:15).

We believe that Christ died on the cross as a substitute for sinners, bearing the wrath of God in their place, and fully satisfying God's justice (Isaiah 53:5–6; Romans 3:25–26; 1 Peter 2:24).

We believe that He was buried and rose again on the third day, demonstrating His victory over sin and death and confirming the acceptance of His sacrifice (1 Corinthians 15:3–4; Romans 4:25).

We believe that salvation is offered freely to all, and that God commands all people everywhere to repent of their sins and believe in the Lord Jesus Christ (Acts 17:30; Mark 1:15; Acts 16:31).

We believe that true saving faith includes repentance—a turning from sin—and a wholehearted trust in Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord (Luke 9:23; Acts 20:21; Romans 10:9–10). Saving faith submits to Christ as Lord, not merely receives Him as Savior.

We believe that all who repent and believe in Christ are forgiven of their sins, declared righteous before God, and given eternal life (John 3:16; Romans 5:1; Romans 8:1).

We reject any gospel that minimizes or ignores the holiness of God or the seriousness of sin (Romans 3:23). We reject any teaching that presents faith as mere intellectual agreement without repentance or submission to Jesus Christ as Lord (Luke 6:46; James 2:17). We reject the idea that salvation can be earned by human works or achieved through personal effort (Ephesians 2:8–9). We reject any message that promises salvation without transformation or denies the necessity of a changed life (2 Corinthians 5:17). We reject any version of the gospel that centers on human happiness, success, or personal fulfillment rather than the glory of God and reconciliation with Him (Galatians 1:6–9).

IX. SALVATION

We believe that salvation is the gracious work of God by which He rescues sinners from sin and its consequences and restores them to a right relationship with Himself (Ephesians 2:8–9; Titus 3:5).

We believe that salvation is found in Jesus Christ alone and is based entirely on His life, death, and resurrection, and not on any human merit or works (Acts 4:12; Romans 5:8).

We believe that salvation is received by grace through faith, and not as a result of human effort, so that no one may boast (Ephesians 2:8–9).

We believe that salvation is the work of God from beginning to end. He purposes, accomplishes, and applies salvation according to His will and for His glory (Romans 8:29–30; Philippians 1:6).

We believe that salvation results in a new life, in which the believer is forgiven, made new, and progressively transformed into the image of Christ (2 Corinthians 5:17; Romans 8:29).

A. Election

We believe that election is the sovereign and gracious act of God by which, before the foundation of the world, He chose in Christ those whom He would save, that they would be holy and conformed to the image of His Son (Ephesians 1:4–5; Romans 8:29; 2 Timothy 1:9).

We believe that this choice was not based on any foreseen faith, works, or merit in man, but solely on God's mercy and purpose according to His will (Romans 9:11–16; Ephesians 1:4–7; Titus 3:5).

We believe that all whom God has chosen will certainly be saved. Those whom He elects, He calls; those whom He calls, He brings to faith; and those who come to Him He receives. God's purpose in election will surely be fulfilled (John 6:37–40, 44; Acts 13:48; Romans 8:30).

We believe that election does not remove the responsibility of all people to repent and believe in Jesus Christ. The gospel is to be proclaimed to all people, and all who come to Christ will be received (John 3:18; John 5:40; Acts 17:30; Revelation 22:17).

We believe that God's sovereign choice is not arbitrary, but is perfectly consistent with His character—His wisdom, justice, holiness, and love—and ultimately brings glory to Him. This doctrine leads to humility, gratitude, and worship (Romans 9:14–16; 1 Corinthians 1:26–31; 2 Timothy 1:9).

We reject the teaching that God's election is based on foreseen faith or human effort (Romans 9:11–16). We reject the belief that salvation ultimately depends on the will or decision of man rather than the grace of God (John 1:13; Romans 9:16). We reject the idea that God's sovereignty removes human responsibility to repent and believe the gospel (Acts 17:30; John 3:18).

B. Effectual Calling

We believe that all those whom God has chosen for salvation, and those only, He effectually calls in His appointed time through His Word and Spirit (Romans 8:30; 2 Thessalonians 2:13–14).

We believe that this calling brings sinners out of their state of sin and spiritual death into new life in Jesus Christ (Ephesians 2:1–5).

We believe that in this calling, God opens the mind to understand the truth, changes the heart, and renews the will. He removes the heart of stone and gives a heart that desires Him, effectually drawing sinners to Jesus Christ (Ezekiel 36:26; Acts 26:18; John 6:44).

We believe that this call is entirely of God's grace and not based on anything foreseen in man. Apart from this work, man is unable to respond to the gospel. But when God gives new life, He enables the sinner to respond and to embrace Christ (Ephesians 2:8–9; 1 Corinthians 2:14).

We believe that all whom God effectually calls will certainly come to Christ. They come freely and willingly, having been made willing by His grace (John 6:37, 44; Psalm 110:3).

We believe that there is a general call of the gospel that goes out to all people, yet not all who hear it are saved. Only those whom God draws will truly come to Christ (Matthew 22:14; John 6:44).

We believe that salvation is found in Jesus Christ alone, and that no one can be saved apart from Him (John 14:6; Acts 4:12).

We reject the teaching that sinners are able to come to Christ apart from God's gracious work in their hearts (John 6:44; 1 Corinthians 2:14). We reject the belief that God's call is merely an invitation that depends on human decision, rather than a powerful work that brings about salvation (Romans 8:30). We reject the idea that people are forced against their will to come to Christ; rather, they come willingly as God changes their hearts (Psalm 110:3). We reject any teaching that salvation can be found apart from Jesus Christ (John 14:6; Acts 4:12).

C. Regeneration

We believe that regeneration is the supernatural work of the Holy Spirit by which a person is given new spiritual life and a new nature. This is the new birth, by which a person is made alive to God (John 3:3–7; 2 Corinthians 5:17; Titus 3:5).

We believe that regeneration is entirely the work of God and not the result of human will, effort, or decision. It is accomplished by the power of the Holy Spirit through the Word of God, that is, through the gospel, and not apart from it (James 1:18; 1 Peter 1:23; Romans 10:17; John 1:13).

We believe that this change is not merely outward, but takes place in the heart. God opens the mind, changes the heart, and gives new desires so that the sinner is able to understand the truth and respond to the gospel (Ezekiel 36:26; 2 Corinthians 4:6).

We believe that regeneration is not a gradual process of moral improvement, but a decisive and immediate act of God.

We believe that regeneration occurs before and results in repentance and faith. Faith is the result of the new birth, not the cause of it. Those who are born again are enabled by the Holy Spirit to believe in Jesus Christ (John 1:13; John 3:3–8; Ezekiel 36:26–27; Acts 16:14; 1 John 5:1).

We believe that God does not force the sinner against his will, but changes the heart so that he willingly comes to Christ (Psalm 110:3).

We believe that regeneration is necessary for salvation, and that no one can enter the kingdom of God unless he is born again (John 3:3).

We believe that those who are born again begin a new life marked by a desire to follow God (2 Corinthians 5:17).

We reject the teaching that regeneration happens apart from the Word of God or the gospel (James 1:18; Romans 10:17). We reject the teaching that regeneration is the result of human will, decision, or effort (John 1:13; Titus 3:5). We reject the belief that faith is the cause of the new birth, rather than the result of it (1 John 5:1). We reject any teaching that a person can be saved without being born again (John 3:3). We reject the idea that regeneration is merely an outward reform or moral improvement, rather than a true change of heart (Ezekiel 36:26).

D. Conversion

We believe that conversion is the response of the sinner to God's work of grace, in which a person turns from sin and turns to God through faith in Jesus Christ (Acts 2:38; Acts 20:21).

We believe that repentance is a real turning from sin, involving sorrow for sin and a desire to forsake it and live in obedience to God (Luke 13:3; Acts 3:19; 2 Corinthians 7:10).

We believe that faith is a personal trust in Jesus Christ alone for salvation, resting on His person and finished work, and not on any human effort or merit (John 3:16; Acts 16:31; Romans 3:22).

We believe that repentance and faith always go together and cannot be separated. To turn to Christ in faith is to turn away from sin, and to turn from sin is to turn to Christ (Mark 1:15; Acts 20:21).

We believe that conversion is the result of God's work in the heart. Because of sin, no one is able to repent or believe apart from God's grace. Through regeneration, the Holy Spirit gives new life and enables sinners to respond freely and willingly to the gospel (John 6:44; Acts 11:18; Philippians 1:29).

We believe that regeneration and conversion are closely connected but not the same. In regeneration, God gives new life to the sinner; in conversion, the sinner responds to God by repenting and believing. Regeneration comes before and makes conversion possible.

We believe that all who truly repent and believe in Jesus Christ are saved and will show evidence of a changed life (John 1:12; 2 Corinthians 5:17).

We reject the teaching that repentance is optional or unnecessary for salvation (Luke 13:3; Acts 3:19). We reject the idea that faith is merely intellectual agreement or a one-time decision, rather than a genuine trust in Christ (James 2:19). We reject any form of "easy-believism" that separates faith from repentance or denies the transforming nature of true conversion (2 Corinthians 5:17). We reject the belief that repentance and faith are works by which a person earns salvation (Ephesians 2:8–9). We reject the teaching that sinners can come to Christ apart from the gracious work of God in their hearts (John 6:44).

E. Justification

We believe that justification is the act of God by which He alone declares righteous those who repent of their sins and believe in Jesus Christ (Romans 8:33; Acts 16:31; Romans 3:26).

We believe that justification includes the full forgiveness of sins and the acceptance of the believer as righteous before God (Romans 4:5–8; Ephesians 1:7).

We believe that justification is a legal declaration and not a change in the sinner's nature. It is distinct from sanctification and is not based on any works, merit, or righteousness of our own (Romans 3:20; Romans 4:4–5).

We believe that in justification, our sins are credited to Christ, and His righteousness is credited to us. Christ lived a perfect life in our place and died to bear the penalty for our sins. In this way, God declares us righteous before Him (2 Corinthians 5:21; Romans 5:18–19; Isaiah 53:5–6).

We believe that justification is received through faith alone, which rests on Christ and His righteousness. Faith is not the basis of our righteousness, but the means by which we receive it (Romans 3:28; Philippians 3:9).

We believe that true saving faith is never alone, but is always accompanied by a changed life and good works (Galatians 5:6; James 2:17).

We believe that through justification, the believer has peace with God and is fully accepted by Him. This justification is a once-for-all act and can never be lost or undone (Romans 5:1; Romans 8:1; John 10:28).

We believe that although justified believers still sin, God continues to forgive them. Yet their sin may affect their fellowship with Him until they repent and turn back to Him (1 John 1:7–9; Psalm 32:5).

We reject the teaching that justification is based on human works, merit, or personal righteousness (Romans 3:20; Galatians 2:16). We reject the idea that righteousness is infused into the believer as the basis of acceptance before God, rather than credited to him through Christ (Romans 4:4–6; 2 Corinthians 5:21). We reject any teaching that justification is by faith plus works, rather than by faith alone (Galatians 2:16; Romans 3:28). We reject the belief that faith itself, or any act of obedience, is the basis of our righteousness before God (Philippians 3:9). We reject the belief that true justification can be lost or undone (John 10:28; Romans 8:1).

F. Sanctification

We believe that every believer is set apart to God at the moment of salvation and is declared holy in Christ. This is a once-for-all work of God that defines the believer's new standing before Him (1 Corinthians 1:2; 6:11; Hebrews 10:10, 14; 1 Peter 1:2).

We believe that all who are united to Christ and born again are also being sanctified. This work of sanctification flows from the believer's union with Jesus Christ. Through the work of the Holy Spirit and the Word of God, believers are progressively changed to become more like Him (Romans 6:5; Romans 8:29; 2 Corinthians 3:18; John 17:17).

We believe that because of Christ's death and resurrection, the power of sin has been broken. Sin no longer rules over the believer, though it still remains (Romans 6:6, 14).

We believe that sanctification involves the whole person (mind, heart, and will) and includes both putting sin to death and growing in righteousness (Galatians 5:24; Colossians 1:11; 1 Thessalonians 5:23).

We believe that this growth takes place as believers walk in obedience to God's Word and depend on the power of the Holy Spirit. As they do so, they truly grow in holiness, though not perfectly in this life (John 17:17; Galatians 5:16; Hebrews 12:14).

We believe that every believer experiences an ongoing struggle between the new life in Christ and the remaining sin within. This conflict continues throughout the Christian life (Galatians 5:16–17; Romans 7:18–23).

We believe that although sin may at times be strong, through the continual work of the Holy Spirit, believers increasingly overcome sin and grow in grace (Romans 6:14; 2 Corinthians 7:1).

We believe that believers are called to pursue holiness, and that without holiness no one will see the Lord (Hebrews 12:14).

We believe that sanctification will be completed when the believer is in the presence of Christ (1 John 3:2).

We reject the teaching that a believer can reach sinless perfection in this life (1 John 1:8; Philippians 3:12). We reject the idea that sanctification is achieved by human effort alone, apart from the work of the Holy Spirit (Galatians 3:3). We reject the belief that true believers will remain unchanged and show no growth in holiness (2 Corinthians 5:17; James 2:17). We reject the idea that believers can live in continual disobedience without growth in holiness (Hebrews 12:14). We reject the idea that sin continues to rule over the believer as it did before conversion (Romans 6:14).

G. Glorification

We believe that glorification is the final and complete work of God in salvation, in which all believers are made perfectly holy and fully conformed to the image of Jesus Christ (Romans 8:30; 1 John 3:2).

We believe that at the return of Christ, believers will be raised bodily and given glorified bodies that are free from sin, corruption, and death (1 Corinthians 15:42–44, 51–53; Philippians 3:20–21).

We believe that in glorification, all sin will be completely removed, and the believer will no longer struggle with sin but will live in perfect righteousness (Ephesians 5:27; Hebrews 12:23).

We believe that glorified believers will dwell forever in the presence of God, enjoying perfect fellowship with Him and seeing Him as He is (Revelation 21:3–4; 22:3–5; 1 John 3:2).

We believe that this final state is certain for all who are in Christ, because God faithfully completes the work He began in them (Romans 8:30; Philippians 1:6).

We reject the denial of the bodily resurrection of believers (1 Corinthians 15:12–14). We reject the idea that salvation is incomplete or uncertain for those who are in Christ (Romans 8:30; Philippians 1:6). We reject any teaching that believers will continue in sin or imperfection in their final state (Revelation 21:27).

H. Perseverance and Assurance of Salvation

We believe that all who are truly saved are kept by God's power and will persevere in faith until the end. Those whom God has justified, He will also glorify (John 10:28–29; Romans 8:30; Philippians 1:6).

We believe that true believers cannot lose their salvation, because their salvation depends on God's grace and not on their own strength (1 Peter 1:5; Hebrews 7:25).

We believe that saving faith results in a changed life, and that those who truly belong to Christ will continue in faith and grow in obedience, though imperfectly (John 8:31; 1 John 2:19).

We believe that believers may have assurance of their salvation, not based on their own performance, but on the promises of God, the finished work of Christ, and the inward testimony of the Holy Spirit (Romans 8:16; 1 John 5:13).

We believe that this assurance may be weakened by sin, doubt, or spiritual neglect, but can be strengthened through the Word of God, prayer, and a life of obedience (2 Peter 1:5–10; 1 John 3:19–21).

We reject the teaching that true believers can lose their salvation or fall away permanently (John 10:28–29). We reject the idea that a person can have saving faith without a transformed life or ongoing obedience to Christ (James 2:17; 1 John 2:3–4). We reject false assurance that is based only on a past decision, profession, or outward activity without evidence of genuine faith (Matthew 7:21–23). We reject the belief that assurance is impossible or that believers can never know whether they are saved (1 John 5:13).

X. CHURCH

A. Universal Church

We believe that the universal church is made up of all true believers in Jesus Christ from every nation, tribe, and generation, whom God has called to Himself. It is the body of Christ, and Christ Himself is its Head and Savior (Ephesians 1:22–23; Colossians 1:18; Ephesians 5:23).

We believe that the universal church is a spiritual body, formed by the work of the Holy Spirit, who unites all believers to Christ and to one another through their union with Him (1 Corinthians 12:12–13; Romans 6:5).

We believe that this universal church is sometimes called the invisible church, since its true members are fully known only to God (2 Timothy 2:19).

We believe that all who are truly saved belong to this one church, regardless of place or time, and are part of the family of God (Hebrews 12:22–23; Ephesians 2:19).

We believe that the church is also described in Scripture as the bride of Christ, loved and redeemed by Him, and will one day be presented to Him in glory (Ephesians 5:25–27; Revelation 19:7).

We believe that the universal church exists for the glory of God and will be fully gathered and perfected in the presence of Christ (Ephesians 5:25–27; Revelation 7:9).

We reject the idea that the universal church is limited to any one denomination, group, or institution (1 Corinthians 12:13). We reject the teaching that the church is merely a

human organization, rather than a spiritual body created by God (Ephesians 1:22–23). We reject the belief that belonging to any visible church or institution is necessary for salvation, apart from personal faith in Jesus Christ (Ephesians 2:8–9; Acts 4:12). We reject the denial of the true, spiritual nature of the church, as though it were only a visible or social organization (2 Timothy 2:19).

B. Local Church

We believe that the local church is a visible gathering of believers in Jesus Christ, established by God and taught clearly in the New Testament (Acts 14:23, 27; Acts 20:28; Titus 1:5).

We believe that each local church is under the authority of Jesus Christ, who is its Head, and is governed by His Word (Colossians 1:18; Matthew 28:18–20).

We believe that the local church is described in Scripture as God's temple, where the Holy Spirit dwells, and as the household of God, a pillar and support of the truth (1 Corinthians 3:16; 1 Timothy 3:15).

We believe that the purpose of the local church is to glorify God through worship, the preaching and teaching of the Word, prayer, fellowship, the building up of believers, and the making of disciples (Acts 2:42; Ephesians 4:11–16; Matthew 28:19–20).

We believe that believers are called to commit themselves to a local church, where they are accountable to one another and grow together in faith and obedience (Acts 2:41–42; Hebrews 10:24–25).

We believe that each local church is to be led by qualified elders who shepherd the flock and are assisted by deacons who serve the needs of the church (1 Timothy 3:1–13; Titus 1:5–9; 1 Peter 5:1–3).

We believe that no local church is perfect, and that within the visible church there may be those who profess faith but are not truly saved (Matthew 7:21–23; Titus 1:15–16; Jude 4).

We reject the idea that a person can live the Christian life apart from commitment to a local church (Hebrews 10:24–25). We reject the teaching that the church is governed by human authority, tradition, or culture rather than the Word of God (Colossians 2:8; 2 Timothy 3:16–17). We reject the belief that leadership in the church is based on personal preference or worldly standards rather than biblical qualifications (1 Timothy 3:1–13). We reject the idea that all who profess faith are truly saved, apart from evidence of a transformed life (Matthew 7:21–23).

C. Church Membership

We believe that church membership is the formal commitment of a believer to a local church, where he or she is recognized as part of the body of Christ and placed under its care, instruction, and accountability (Acts 2:41–42; Hebrews 13:17).

We believe that all who profess repentance toward God and faith in the Lord Jesus Christ are called to identify with and commit themselves to a local church. This commitment involves faithful participation in the life of the church, including worship, fellowship, the ordinances, and service (Acts 2:41–42; 1 Corinthians 12:12–13; Hebrews 10:24–25).

We believe that church membership establishes a mutual responsibility between the believer and the church. Members are called to pursue holiness, love one another, submit to biblical leadership, and use their gifts for the building up of the body (Ephesians 4:11–16; 1 Peter 5:5). At the same time, the church is responsible to shepherd, teach, care for, and, when necessary, discipline its members according to Scripture (Acts 20:28; Matthew 18:15–17).

We believe that membership helps make visible the distinction between the church and the world, affirming those who belong to Christ and guarding the purity and testimony of the church (1 Corinthians 5:12–13).

We reject the idea that a believer can live faithfully apart from commitment to a local church (Hebrews 10:24–25). We reject the view that church membership is optional, informal, or unnecessary for the Christian life. We reject the practice of receiving into membership those who do not give a credible profession of faith in Jesus Christ (Matthew 7:21–23). We reject any understanding of membership that lacks accountability, discipline, or meaningful participation in the life of the church.

D. Ordinances

1. Water Baptism

We believe that baptism is an ordinance of the New Testament, instituted by the Lord Jesus Christ, and is a sign of a believer's union with Him in His death, burial, and resurrection (Romans 6:3–5; Colossians 2:12).

We believe that baptism is a visible picture of the gospel, showing outwardly what God has done inwardly in the life of the believer. It represents the forgiveness of sins, new life in Christ, and a new identity in Him (Romans 6:4; 2 Corinthians 5:17).

We believe that baptism is the believer's first act of obedience to Christ and is a public declaration of faith in Him. Through baptism, the believer openly identifies with Jesus Christ and with His people (Acts 2:41; Acts 8:12).

We believe that baptism also marks a person's entrance into the visible church, setting apart those who belong to Christ from the world (Acts 2:41–42).

We believe that baptism is to be administered only to those who personally repent of their sins and believe in Jesus Christ. Therefore, it is for believers alone (Acts 2:41; Acts 18:8).

We believe that baptism is to be performed in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit (Matthew 28:19).

We believe that baptism is to be administered by immersion in water, which best represents the believer's union with Christ in His death and resurrection (Matthew 3:16; John 3:23; Romans 6:4).

We believe that baptism does not save or remove sin, but is a sign and testimony of the salvation that has already taken place by grace through faith (Ephesians 2:8–9).

We reject the teaching that baptism is necessary for salvation or that it removes sin (Ephesians 2:8–9). We reject the practice of baptizing those who do not personally profess repentance and faith in Jesus Christ. We reject the view that baptism is merely a private or personal act, rather than a public declaration of faith in Christ and identification with His church. We reject the view that baptism is merely a ritual without spiritual meaning or significance (Romans 6:3–4).

2. Lord's Supper

We believe that the Lord's Supper is an ordinance of the New Testament, instituted by the Lord Jesus Christ, to be observed by His church in remembrance of Him (Luke 22:19; 1 Corinthians 11:23–25).

We believe that the Lord's Supper is a visible proclamation of the gospel, remembering the sacrificial death of Christ, declaring His death until He comes, and anticipating the glory of His kingdom (1 Corinthians 11:26).

We believe that the bread and the cup are symbols that represent the body and blood of Christ, and do not become His actual body and blood (1 Corinthians 11:24–25).

We believe that the Lord's Supper is to be observed by believers as an act of worship, thanksgiving, and fellowship with Christ and with one another (1 Corinthians 10:16–17).

We believe that participation in the Lord's Supper is to be done with reverence and self-examination. Believers must examine themselves and come in repentance and faith, recognizing the seriousness of this ordinance (1 Corinthians 11:27–29).

We believe that the Lord's Supper is for those who are truly believers in Jesus Christ and who are not living in unrepentant sin (1 Corinthians 11:17–34).

We believe that the Lord's Supper is to be observed in the gathered church and is not merely a private or individual act (1 Corinthians 11:18, 20).

We reject the teaching that the Lord's Supper becomes the actual body and blood of Christ or that it offers a repeated sacrifice for sin (Hebrews 10:10–14). We reject the idea that participation in the Lord's Supper saves or gives grace apart from faith (Ephesians 2:8–9). We reject the careless or unworthy participation in the Lord's Supper without repentance and self-examination (1 Corinthians 11:27–29). We reject the view that the Lord's Supper is merely a private or individual act, rather than a corporate ordinance of the church (1 Corinthians 11:18, 20). We reject the view that the Lord's Supper is an empty ritual without spiritual meaning or significance (1 Corinthians 10:16–17).

E. Lord's Day

We believe that the first day of the week, known as the Lord's Day, is the day set apart by the New Testament pattern for the gathered worship of the church, in remembrance of the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead (Acts 20:7; 1 Corinthians 16:2; Revelation 1:10; Matthew 28:1).

We believe that Jesus Christ is the Lord of the Sabbath (Mark 2:27–28), and that in Him the true rest of God is fulfilled. Through His finished work, He gives rest to the souls of all who come to Him in faith (Matthew 11:28–30; Hebrews 4:3, 9–10). The Lord's Day, therefore, is not a continuation of the Old Testament Sabbath as a legal system, but a joyful celebration of the rest we have in Christ and the new life we have through His resurrection.

We believe that on the Lord's Day, believers are called to gather together for the preaching of the Word, prayer, fellowship, and the observance of the ordinances, as part of the ordinary means by which God strengthens and builds His church (Acts 2:42; 1 Timothy 4:13; Hebrews 10:24–25).

We believe that the regular and faithful gathering of the church on the Lord's Day is essential to the Christian life. It is a primary expression of devotion to Christ, love for His people, and obedience to His Word (Hebrews 10:25; John 14:15; John 13:34–35).

We believe that believers are to honor and prioritize the Lord's Day, willingly setting aside competing interests in order to devote themselves to worship, spiritual growth, and fellowship with God's people (Colossians 3:16; Psalm 122:1).

We reject the neglect of the Lord's Day or the habitual absence from the gathered worship of the church without valid reason, recognizing that such neglect is a serious failure to obey God's command and a disregard for the means He has given for our spiritual growth (Hebrews 10:25; Luke 6:46). We reject the idea that corporate worship is optional, secondary, or replaceable in the Christian life (Acts 2:42; Ephesians 4:11–16). We reject a legalistic view that treats the Lord's Day as a binding system of external rules patterned after the Old Testament Sabbath, rather than a Christ-centered gathering for worship (Mark 2:27; Romans 14:5–6; Colossians 2:16–17). We reject a careless or indifferent attitude toward the worship of God, which fails to recognize His holiness and the privilege of gathering with His people (Ecclesiastes 5:1; Hebrews 12:28–29).

F. Church Discipline

We believe that church discipline is a biblical responsibility given by the Lord Jesus Christ to the local church for the purpose of restoring sinning believers, maintaining the purity of the church, and upholding the honor of Christ (Matthew 18:15–17; 1 Corinthians 5:6–7).

We believe that church discipline is to be carried out in love, humility, and patience, with the goal of repentance and restoration, not punishment (Galatians 6:1).

We believe that when a believer falls into sin, he/she is to be corrected privately, and if he/she refuses to repent, the matter is to be addressed with increasing seriousness according to the teaching of Scripture (Matthew 18:15–17).

We believe that if a person continues in unrepentant sin, the church must take appropriate action, including, if necessary, removing him/her from membership, treating him/her as an unbeliever, and calling him/her to repentance (1 Corinthians 5:11–13; 2 Thessalonians 3:6).

We believe that church discipline applies to all members of the church and is necessary for the spiritual health of the body (Hebrews 12:11).

We reject the neglect of church discipline, which allows sin to remain unchecked in the church (1 Corinthians 5:6–7). We reject the practice of discipline that is harsh, abusive, or lacking in love and humility (Galatians 6:1). We reject the idea that professing believers may continue in unrepentant sin without correction or consequence (Matthew 18:15–17). We reject the belief that the church has no responsibility to guard its membership and uphold holiness (1 Corinthians 5:12–13).

G. Church Mission

We believe that the mission of the church is to glorify God by making disciples of all nations through the proclamation of the gospel of Jesus Christ (Matthew 28:19–20; Mark 16:15).

We believe that this mission includes faithfully preaching the Word of God, calling sinners to repentance and faith in Jesus Christ, baptizing those who believe, and teaching them to obey all that Christ has commanded (Matthew 28:19–20; Acts 2:38–42).

We believe that the church is called not only to proclaim the gospel but also to build up believers, equipping them for spiritual maturity and faithful service (Ephesians 4:11–13).

We believe that the church is to be a witness to the world, displaying the character of Christ through lives of holiness, love, and unity (John 13:34–35; Philippians 2:15; 1 Peter 2:9).

We believe that the mission of the church is primarily spiritual and gospel-centered, addressing the greatest need of humanity which is reconciliation with God through Jesus Christ (2 Corinthians 5:18–20).

We reject the idea that the primary mission of the church is social, political, or cultural transformation apart from the preaching of the gospel (Matthew 28:19–20). We reject the neglect of evangelism and discipleship as central responsibilities of the church (Mark 16:15). We reject the teaching that the church's mission can be fulfilled apart from the faithful proclamation of God's Word (Romans 10:14–17). We reject any misuse of the doctrines of God's sovereignty or election that leads to passivity, neglect

of evangelism, or failure to actively participate in the means God has ordained to accomplish His saving purposes (Matthew 28:19–20; Romans 10:14–15).

XI. ANGELS

A. Holy Angels

We believe that holy angels are created beings, made by God to serve Him and to carry out His will (Colossians 1:16; Psalm 103:20).

We believe that angels are spiritual beings who are not to be worshiped, but are servants of God and ministers to those who will inherit salvation (Hebrews 1:14; Revelation 22:8–9).

We believe that angels continually worship God and carry out His commands, acting as His messengers and agents according to His sovereign purpose (Isaiah 6:1–3; Luke 1:26–28).

We believe that God uses angels to accomplish His purposes in the world, including protecting, guiding, and serving His people according to His will (Psalm 91:11–12; Hebrews 1:14; Acts 12:7–10).

We believe that angels are not to be prayed to, trusted in, or given any form of worship, but that all worship belongs to God alone (Colossians 2:18; Revelation 19:10).

We reject the worship of angels or the giving of honor that belongs to God alone (Revelation 22:8–9). We reject the teaching that angels are independent powers or act outside of God's authority (Psalm 103:20). We reject speculative teachings about angels that go beyond what is revealed in Scripture (Deuteronomy 29:29).

B. Fallen Angels

We believe that Satan is a created angel who rebelled against God and became the enemy of God and His people (Luke 10:18; 1 Timothy 3:6; Revelation 12:7–9; 2 Peter 2:4; Jude 6; Isaiah 14:12–15; Ezekiel 28:11–17).

We believe that through his rebellion, Satan led many angels into sin, who are now known as demons and are under God's judgment (Matthew 25:41; Revelation 12:3–4).

We believe that Satan was the tempter in the fall of man, introducing sin into the human race through his deception of Adam and Eve (Genesis 3:1–6).

We believe that Satan is the enemy of God, actively opposing His truth, His kingdom, and His purposes. He deceives the world, blinds unbelievers to the truth of the gospel, tempts mankind to sin, and seeks the destruction of those made in the image of God (Matthew 4:1–11; John 8:44; 2 Corinthians 4:4; 1 Peter 5:8; Revelation 12:9).

We believe that although Satan is powerful, he is not equal to God and operates only within the limits permitted by God's sovereign will (Job 1:6–12).

We believe that Satan has been decisively defeated through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ and that his final judgment is certain (Colossians 2:15; Romans 16:20).

We believe that Satan and all fallen angels will be eternally punished in the lake of fire (Matthew 25:41; Revelation 20:10).

We reject the idea that Satan is equal with God or that there is a dual power between good and evil. We reject the belief that Satan acts independently of God's authority or outside of His sovereign control (Job 1:12). We reject the denial of the reality of Satan and demons as personal, spiritual beings (1 Peter 5:8). We reject excessive speculation or unhealthy focus on demonic activity beyond what Scripture teaches (Deuteronomy 29:29).

XII. LAST THINGS

We believe that Jesus Christ will return personally, visibly, and in glory at a time known only to God (Acts 1:11; Matthew 24:36).

We believe that there will be a future resurrection of all people, both the righteous and the unrighteous (John 5:28–29; Acts 24:15).

We believe that God has appointed a day in which He will judge the world in righteousness through Jesus Christ (Acts 17:31; 2 Corinthians 5:10).

We believe that those who have trusted in Christ will be raised to eternal life and will dwell forever in the presence of God, in the new heavens and new earth (John 3:16; Revelation 21:1–4).

We believe that those who reject Christ will be raised to judgment and will face eternal punishment, separated from the presence of God (Matthew 25:46; 2 Thessalonians 1:8–9).

We believe that Christ will reign forever, and that God will be glorified in the final fulfillment of all His purposes (Revelation 22:3–5).

We reject the denial of the personal and visible return of Jesus Christ (Acts 1:11). We reject the denial of the resurrection of the body (1 Corinthians 15:12–14). We reject the idea that there will be no final judgment of all people (Acts 17:31). We reject the teaching that all people will ultimately be saved regardless of faith in Christ (Matthew 25:46). We reject the belief that eternal punishment is temporary or symbolic rather than real and everlasting (2 Thessalonians 1:8–9).